SALESFORCE ADMIN COURSE • EPISODE 39

My Domain, Login Access & Session Security

Deep-Dive Identity & Session Architecture: Custom Subdomains, Instance Mobility, Impersonation Governance (Login As), Inactivity Timeouts, and High Assurance Session Policies.

- 🌐 My Domain: Unique Org Web Identity
- 🆔 Username vs. My Domain Decoded
- ⚠️ Renaming My Domain: Dependencies & Risks
- 👥 Login Access Policies: "Login As" Governance
- ⏱️ Session Settings: Timeouts & Force Logout
- 🛡️ Standard vs. High Assurance (MFA) Sessions

Created by Sachin • Salesforce Certified Administrator Series • Duration: ~22–26 Mins

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1. Introduction: From Access Control to Session Architecture

Over the preceding episodes, we mastered the core access layers: Organization-Level, Object-Level (CRUD), Field-Level (FLS), and Record-Level (OWD, Sharing, and Restriction Rules).

Today, we zoom into the foundational infrastructure that powers how users enter the system and how their authenticated connections are maintained: **My Domain**, **Login Access Policies**, and **Session Security**.

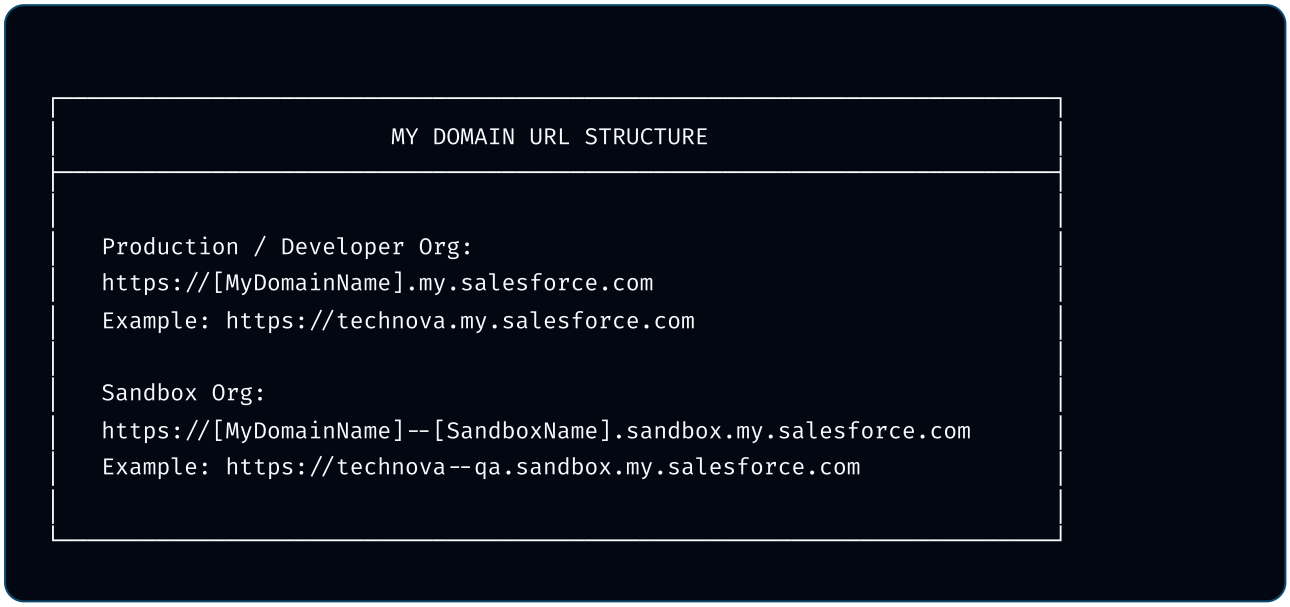
> *"Login security protects the entrance gate to Salesforce; Session security protects the authenticated connection after the user enters."*

2. What is My Domain?

My Domain gives your Salesforce organization a customer-specific subdomain within the official Salesforce domain structure.

```
https://yourcompany.my.salesforce.com
```

Instead of relying on generic public entry points, your organization receives a dedicated, branded digital identity. In modern Salesforce releases, **My Domain is enabled by default** for all new organizations and is an architectural prerequisite for modern Salesforce features.



3. Why is My Domain Crucial?

My Domain is not just an aesthetic web address. It is a fundamental technical pillar across four critical areas:

1. Organization Branding & Trust

Provides visual trust on the login screen. Users immediately recognize your corporate brand, logo, and background rather than a generic Salesforce page.

2. Authentication Backbone

My Domain is **technically mandatory** to configure **Single Sign-On (SSO)** with SAML / OpenID Connect, third-party Auth Providers (Google, Apple), and Multi-Factor Authentication policies.

3. Modern Lightning Customization

All custom Lightning Web Components (LWC), Aura components, and Experience Cloud sites rely on My Domain endpoints for component rendering and security sandboxing.

4. Instance Mobility & Integrations

If Salesforce moves your org from instance `NA12` to `NA45` during scheduled infrastructure rebalancing, My Domain URLs remain 100% stable without breaking code or API endpoints!

4. Generic Login URLs vs. My Domain URLs

LOGIN URL TYPE	TRADITIONAL DEFAULT URL	ORG-SPECIFIC MY DOMAIN URL
Production / Dev Org	`https://login.salesforce.com`	`https://technova.my.salesforce.com`
Sandbox Org	`https://test.salesforce.com`	`https://technova--dev.sandbox.my.salesforce.com`
Supports SSO?	No (Generic)	Yes (Direct SAML / SSO routing)
Instance Resilient?	Requires redirect routing	Fully Resilient (Seamless routing)

> **Best Practice:** Always instruct end users and integration engineers to use your dedicated **My Domain Login URL** rather than generic `login.salesforce.com` endpoints.

5. Username vs. My Domain (The Essential Distinction)

Beginners frequently conflate user account names with org domain names. Let's make this crystal clear:

👤 Username (Identity: WHO)

- Identifies the **individual human user**.
- Format: Email format (e.g. `rahul@technova.com`).
- Must be **globally unique** across all Salesforce orgs in the world.
- Does not have to be a working inbox.

🏢 My Domain (Identity: WHERE)

- Identifies the **entire Salesforce organization / tenant**.
- Format: Subdomain URL (e.g. `technova.my.salesforce.com`).
- Shared by **all users** logging into that specific enterprise tenant.

6. Changing My Domain: Precautions & Risks

Can an organization change its My Domain? **Yes.** If your company rebrands, merges, or changes legal entity names, you can rename the domain via:

```
Setup ➔ Company Settings ➔ My Domain ➔ My Domain Details ➔ Edit
```

CRITICAL PRODUCTION WARNING: Renaming My Domain carries high disruption risk!
Changing your My Domain alters login and application endpoints. It can immediately break:

- Single Sign-On (SAML Entity IDs and reply URLs will mismatch).
- Connected Apps and API integrations targeting the old domain.
- Hard-coded URLs in email templates, formula fields, Apex classes, and knowledge articles.
- Registered MFA devices and WebAuthn authenticators.

Mandatory Rule: Always test domain changes thoroughly in a full sandbox and coordinate an enterprise maintenance window before touching production!

7. Login Access Policies & Admin "Login As"

When users run into security roadblocks (e.g., *"I can't see the Opportunity stage button"* or *"This tab is missing for me"*), admins need to see exactly what the user is experiencing.

In Salesforce, administrators can use the **"Login As"** feature:

KEY SETTING **Administrators Can Log in as Any User**

```
Setup ➔ Security ➔ Login Access Policies
```

When this checkbox is **Enabled**, System Administrators can go to `Setup ➔ Users`, click the **Login** link next to any user's name, and immediately enter their session without requiring the user to grant access first.

If this setting is **Disabled**, the individual user must manually navigate to their Personal Settings and grant login access to administrators for a designated time window (e.g., 1 day, 1 week).

Governance Note: Every time an administrator logs in as another user, Salesforce records an immutable event in the **Setup Audit Trail** to preserve auditability and prevent unauthorized impersonation.

8. Session Security: Timeouts & Hijack Protection

Once a user successfully authenticates, an encrypted session is created. **Session Settings** dictate how that session is maintained and protected against unauthorized access.

```
Setup ➔ Security ➔ Session Settings
```

⏱️ Session Timeout

Specifies how long a session can remain idle before expiring (choices range from 15 minutes to 24 hours; recommended: **15–30 minutes** for sensitive environments).

🚪 Force Logout on Timeout

When checked, immediately terminates the session and redirects the browser to the login page upon expiration, rather than waiting for user interaction.

🔒 Lock Sessions to IP

Locks the session cookie to the initial client IP address. Prevents session hijacking, but can cause disconnections for mobile users switching cell towers/Wi-Fi.

> **Breach Containment:** In Session Settings, enabling *"Terminate all of a user's sessions when their password is reset"* ensures that if an account is compromised, resetting the password instantly kills all active sessions across all devices!

9. Session Security Levels: Standard vs. High Assurance

Salesforce associates a **Session Security Level** with each session based on the strength of the authentication method used:

1. Standard Session

Established via basic, single-factor authentication (e.g., standard Username + Password). Suitable for daily general navigation, but lacks higher cryptographic trust.

2. High Assurance Session

Established via strong, multi-factor authentication (e.g., Salesforce Authenticator, FIDO2/WebAuthn Passkeys, YubiKey). **MFA authentication automatically creates a High Assurance session by default.**

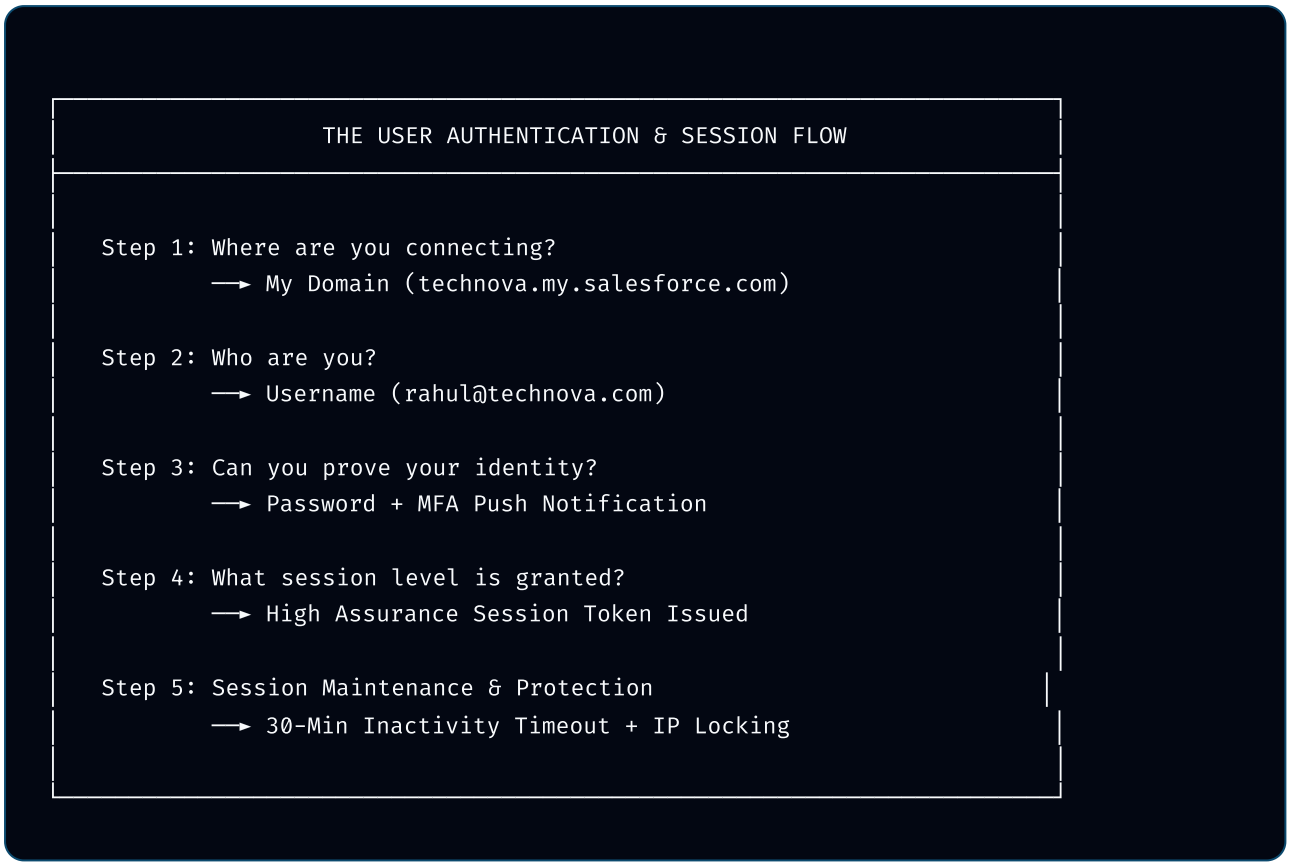
High Assurance Step-Up Policies

Administrators can protect high-risk operations by requiring a High Assurance session:

- Accessing sensitive corporate Reports or Dashboards.
- Authorizing Connected Apps or external data integrations.
- Managing sensitive Setup areas (e.g. Identity Providers, Certificate Management).

If a user logged in with a Standard session attempts to access a High Assurance resource, Salesforce performs **Step-Up Authentication**: prompting them to complete an MFA challenge before access is granted!

10. The Complete Identity & Session Funnel



11. Hands-On Practical Demonstration (5 Core Steps)

STEP 01 — **Inspect Your Org's My Domain**

```
Setup ➔ Company Settings ➔ My Domain
```

Locate your *Current My Domain URL*. Note how it incorporates your unique subdomain prefix (e.g., `yourcompany.my.salesforce.com`). Review the *Routing and Policies* section.

STEP 02 — **Compare My Domain with Username**

```
Setup ➔ Users ➔ Users ➔ Open Rahul's Record
```

Inspect Rahul's **Username** field (e.g. `rahul@technova.com`). Notice that while Rahul's username identifies his user account, he navigates to the org via the organization's My Domain URL.

STEP 03

Enable "Administrators Can Log in as Any User" & Test

```
Setup ➔ Login Access Policies ➔ Check "Administrators Can Log in as Any User" ➔ Save
```

1. Navigate to `Setup ➔ Users`.
2. Click the **Login** button next to Rahul.
3. Observe that your browser enters Rahul's exact session context. You can now verify his visible tabs, permissions, and records from his perspective.
4. Click **Log out as Rahul** on the top banner to return to your Admin session.

STEP 04

Configure Session Timeout & Force Logout

```
Setup ➔ Security ➔ Session Settings
```

1. Under *Session Timeout*, configure **Timeout value** (e.g., 30 minutes).
2. Check **Force logout on session timeout**.
3. Click **Save** at the bottom of the page.

STEP 05

Review Session Security Levels (Standard vs High Assurance)

```
Setup ➔ Security ➔ Session Settings ➔ Session Security Levels
```

Inspect the columns: *Standard* and *High Assurance*. Verify that **Multi-Factor Authentication** is listed under High Assurance. Understand how MFA automatically awards High Assurance status to user sessions.

12. Key Takeaways & Episode Summary

1. My Domain is Org Identity

My Domain provides your unique Salesforce URL. It is mandatory for SSO, MFA, Lightning Web Components, and ensures instance mobility during server migrations.

2. Username vs. Domain

Username answers *"Who are you?"*. **My Domain** answers *"Which organization tenant are you accessing?"*.

3. Controlled Impersonation

Login Access Policies allow administrators to log in as users for troubleshooting. Every login is logged in the Setup Audit Trail for compliance.

4. High Assurance Trust

MFA creates High Assurance sessions. Administrators can restrict sensitive operations (exporting reports, connected apps) to require High Assurance authentication.

13. Next Episode Preview

📺 Coming Up in Episode 40: Security Auditing, Setup Audit Trail & Health Check

How do administrators verify that their org conforms to security best practices? In Episode 40, we explore the **Salesforce Health Check** (calculating org security scores against Salesforce baseline baselines), track administrative changes using the **View Setup Audit Trail**, and review **Login History** for forensic investigations!